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1. Introduction

Cyber security is the protection of digital devices and their communication channels, to keep them stable, dependable and free from danger or threat. In present days, we all are very reliant on technology and are feeding those technological devices our data. The importance of cybersecurity has never been the most essential as it is of today. Nowadays, there are lots and lots of cyber security threats (Those malicious activities or attempts to exploit vulnerabilities in systems, networks or data with the intent to steal, damage or disrupt) that have been emerging. Those who carry out these cyber security threats are known as cyber threat actors. Cyber threat actors can be categorized by their motivations and, to a degree, by their sophistication (Security, 2022).

a. By Motivation:

Cyber threat actors can be grouped based on what drives them:

1. Financial Gain: Cybercriminals who hack to steal money, like ransomware gangs demanding payments.
2. Espionage: State-sponsored groups, like APT 1, aiming to steal trade secrets or military intelligence.
3. Ideology: Hacktivists who attack to promote political or social causes, such as Anonymous.
4. Revenge or Personal Grudges: Disgruntled employees or insiders leaking data to harm their organization.

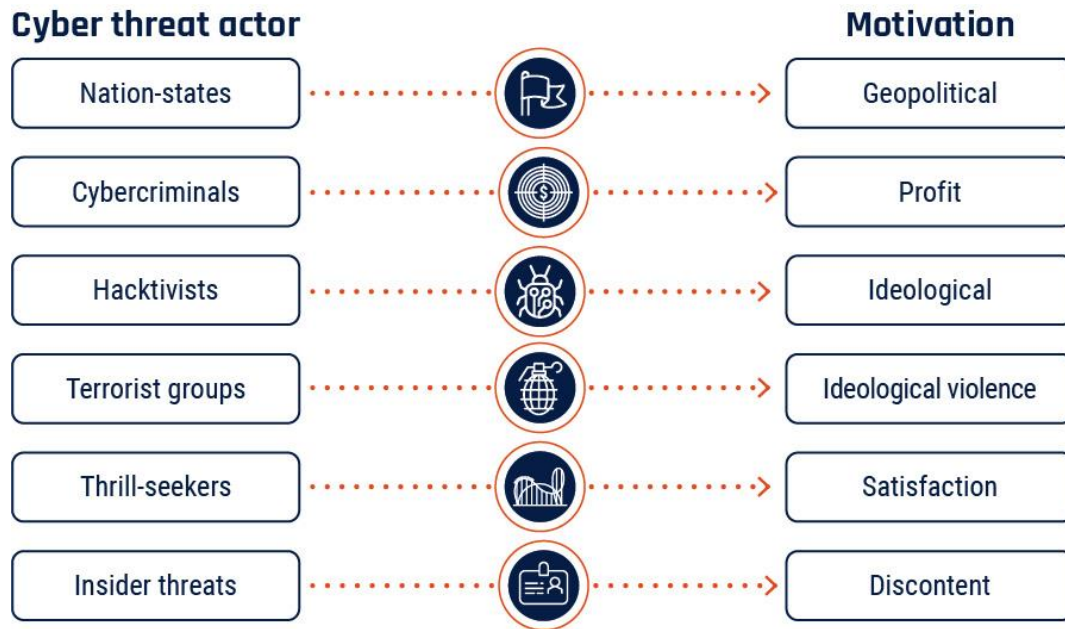


Figure 1: Cyber threat actors and their motivation. (techyv, 2024)

b. By Level of Sophistication:

One of the factors that helps in categorizing cyber security threat actors is the level of sophistication. Some of the cyber security threat actors based on the level of sophistication are as followed: -

- i. APT (Advance Persistent Threats)
- ii. Cybercriminals
- iii. Hactivists
- iv. Insider threats, etc

1.1 Introduction to Advance Persistent Threats (APT)

An Advance Persistent Threat (APT) is a highly sophisticated cyber attack in which the attacker intrudes the victim's network or devices for a prolonged period of time while being undetected for the sake of stealing sensitive and crucial information and data through out their time of intrusion. (Baker, 2025).

An APT typically follows the following life cycles:

- a. Reconnaissance: Gathering intel on the target, like employee details or network layouts.
- b. Initial Compromise: Breaking in, often through phishing emails or software vulnerabilities.
- c. Persistence: Setting up backdoors to stay in the system even after reboots.
- d. Privilege Escalation: Gaining higher access levels to reach sensitive areas.
- e. Lateral Movement: Spreading across the network to find valuable data.
- f. Data Exfiltration: Stealing and sending data to external servers.
- g. Command and Control (C2): Maintaining remote control over the compromised system.
- h. Covering Tracks: Erasing evidence to avoid detection.

APTs mostly maintain their access for a long period of time. i.e. for months or even years. In recent years, many countries such as China, Russia, Iran, and so on have been linked with some kind of APT (Security, 2022). This project is going to cover the topic of APT 1.

1.1.1 APT 1 – China’s “Comment Crew”

APT 1, also notoriously known as the Comment Crew or the Shanghai Group is one of the earliest documented APTs. This APT was found to be linked with the 2nd Bureau of the People’s Liberation army (PLA) and Military Unit Cover Designator (MCUD unit 61398) of China (Mandiant, 2013). This whole attack started way back in 2006. The APT group is associated with PLA Unit 61398, located in a 12-story building in the Pudong district of Shanghai. According to the Mandiant report, this unit operates under the Third Department of the PLA General Staff Department (GSD) — the Chinese military’s main signals intelligence agency. APT 1 is known for causing lots of havoc and to different companies as well (Mandiant, 2013).

Typical Targets of APT 1

Target	Description
Aerospace	Companies involved in aircraft design and manufacturing.
Information Technology	Firms specializing in software development and IT services.
Energy	Organizations in the oil, gas, and alternative energy sectors.
Telecommunications	Providers of communication infrastructure and services.
Manufacturing	Enterprises producing high-tech equipment and machinery.

Table 1 Targets of APT 1 (Mandiant, 2013).

Notably, APT1 has been responsible for:

- a. Targeting over 140 companies across 20+ industries.

- b. Exfiltrating terabytes of data, including design blueprints, negotiation strategies, and communications with government entities.
- c. Demonstrating a clear alignment between their operations and the strategic interests of the Chinese government, such as accessing information related to national defence programs (Mandiant, 2013).

Among all the typical targets, the major one was aerospace and one of the major victims of this APT was “Lockheed Martin” (An American defence cooperation for aerospace manufacture and defence). The attack was initially started by sending spear fishing emails to the employees of Lockheed Martin and when the cyber threat actors were able to gain access, they stole crucial data from the company like the blue print and the plans of the F-35 jet (The most stealth fighter jet) (Mandiant, 2013).

The group was publicly exposed in a landmark 2013 report by cyber security firm Mandiant after a team from McAfee (An American global computer security company) broke into the APT 1's servers in china where all the stolen documents were found, which linked APT1 to China's military and detailed its extensive cyber espionage operations over several years. Due to the use of many rats in this APT, McAfee even named this APT 1 “Operation Shady Rat” and the team were able to undercover the fact that there was a huge RAT network created from this APT. After getting exposed, China denied conducting any offensive cyber operation but agreed not to conduct or support cyber theft of any intellectual property. After so, Chinese hackers started using redirectors to try to hide their trail redirected the packets through different countries (Mandiant, 2013).

2. Section 1

2.1 Case Study: APT 1's cyber-attack on Lockheed Martin

The attack on Lockheed Martin was carried out in 2007 by the APT 1 group by using various malwares and social engineering attacks. This attack was active for about 5 years (2007 to 2012) before being addressed and investigated. The main aim of this hack was to gain confidential information out of USA's defence system and use that information which contained the blue prints of the new latest stealth fighter jet and create a replica of it helping China to gain the upper hand when it came to any kind of security threat linked with the military.

2.2 Motive behind

The main motive of APT 1 to attack Lockheed Martin are as followed: -

- A. Lockheed Martin was the primary and the biggest contractor for the advance military defence technologies like the F-35 Stricker jet.
- B. China wanted to close the technological gap with their competition i.e. western country even if it meant hacking into their systems.
- C. To massively enhance China's own defence capabilities and to gain confidential information and insights of USA's aero space defences.

2.3 Life cycle of APT 1

APT1 used a multi-phase, highly tailored approach to deploy malware into Lockheed Martin's network. The life cycle of APT 1 while attacking Lockheed Martin and the TTPS used are as followed: -

1. Reconnaissance

Objective: Gather intelligence about Lockheed Martin's infrastructure, employees, and digital assets.

Tactic: Gathering Organizational Intelligence

Technique: APT1 used open-source intelligence (OSINT), including job postings, employee details, and public contracts to identify Lockheed Martin's network structure and key personnel (MITRE, 2017).

Toolset monitored: Passive foot printing via websites, defence publications, and LinkedIn.

2. Initial Access

Objective: Gain initial access to the internal network.

Tactic: Spear Phishing via Email and Malwares

Technique (T1566.001): Highly tailored phishing emails were sent to Lockheed Martin employees with malicious Microsoft Office or PDF attachments that contained embedded malware and RATs (MITRE, 2017).

Example: Fake project updates mimicking real defence contract communications.

3. Execution

Objective: Executed different malware to ensure intrusion.

Tactic: Command Execution via Malicious Documents

Technique (T1203 / T1059): Malware was executed using macros or exploit kits that triggered once the user opened a crafted file (zero-days in Java/Adobe were common vectors) (MITRE, 2017).

Payloads: Custom Remote Access Trojans (RATs) like WEBC2, BISCUIT, and NEWSREELS.

4. Persistence

Objective: Maintain long-term, stealthy access to Lockheed Martin's systems.

Tactic: Backdoor Deployment

Technique (T1053.005 / T1547): Scheduled tasks and registry keys were modified to maintain persistence across reboots (MITRE, 2017).

Behaviour: Malware re-established connection if the system restarted.

5. Privilege Escalation & Credential Access

Objective: Move from standard user access to administrative/system-level privileges.

Tactic: Local Privilege Exploitation

Technique (T1003): Harvested credentials using tools like Mimi Katz, dumped LSASS memory, and created admin-level accounts to move laterally (MITRE, 2017).

6. Lateral Movement

Objective: Navigate through Lockheed Martin's internal network to reach sensitive assets.

Tactic: Internal Network Propagation

Technique (T1021.002): Used SMB (Windows Admin Shares) and PS Exec to move from compromised systems to critical assets (e.g., engineering servers, source code repositories) (MITRE, 2017).

7. Data Exfiltration

Objective: Gather and send out critical defence-related data.

Tactic: Exfiltrate via Encrypted Channels

Technique (T1041): Stolen data was compressed, encrypted (e.g., using RAR), and exfiltrated via HTTPS or custom protocols to Command and Control servers (MITRE, 2017).

Types of Data Stolen: Technical designs (e.g., for the F-35 fighter jet), Software source code, Communications with the DoD (Department of Defence)

Impact: Design schematics and subsystem details for advanced fighter aircraft like the F-35.

8. Command and Control (C2C)

Objective: - Remotely control the compromised device and send new files back to the attackers, and keep the malwares updated.

Tactic: Maintain Remote Access

Technique (T1071.001): Used HTTP/S-based C2 with fall back IPs and domains hosted across multiple countries to mask origin (Shanghai-based operations) (MITRE, 2017).

Obfuscation: Encrypted payloads and dynamic DNS to avoid detection.

9. Covering Tracks

Objective: Erase evidence of the intrusion and avoid future detection.

Tactics: Log Deletion: Removed Windows Event Logs and IDS (Intrusion Detection System) alerts, Timestamp Manipulation: Used time stamping to backdate malware file creation, proxying: Routed C2 traffic through compromised U.S. university systems to obfuscate origin (MITRE, 2017).

Summary of Attack lifecycle in tabular format:

Table 2 Summary (MITRE, 2017)

Phase	Description	Tactics	Techniques	Procedure
Reconnaissance	Gather intelligence on Lockheed Martin's infrastructure and personnel.	Gathering Organizational Intelligence	OSINT (Open Source Intelligence)	Used job postings, LinkedIn, defence publications, and websites to map network structure and key individuals.
Initial Access	Gain initial access to the internal network.	Spear Phishing via Email and Malware	T1566.001 – Phishing with attachments	Sent fake project emails with malicious Office/PDF attachments that deployed RATs when opened.
Execution	Deploy malware and execute code on target systems.	Command Execution via Malicious Docs	T1203 – Exploitation for Client Execution T1059 – Command and Scripting Interpreter	Used macros or zero-day exploits in Java/Adobe to run payloads embedded in documents.

Persistence	Maintain long-term, stealthy access after system reboots.	Backdoor Deployment	T1053.005 – Scheduled Task/Job T1547 – Boot or Logon Auto start Execution	Modified registry and scheduled tasks so malware reconnected even after reboots.
Privilege Escalation & Credential Access	Elevate privileges and extract credentials.	Local Privilege Exploitation	T1003 – OS Credential Dumping	Used tools like Mimi Katz to dump LSASS memory and create admin-level accounts.
Lateral Movement	Move across the internal network to find sensitive assets.	Internal Network Propagation	T1021.002 – SMB/Windows Admin Shares	Used SMB and PS Exec to access high-value targets like engineering servers and code repositories.
Data Exfiltration	Steal sensitive defence-related data.	Exfiltration via Encrypted Channels	T1041 – Exfiltration Over C2 Channel	Compressed/encrypted files with RAR and exfiltrated via HTTPS or custom protocols to external C2 servers.
Command & Control	Maintain control over infected machines.	Maintain Remote Access	T1071.001 – Application Layer Protocol: Web Protocols	Used HTTPS with dynamic DNS and multiple domains/IPs to communicate with malware and issue commands.
Covering Tracks	Remove traces to avoid detection.	Defence Evasion	Log Deletion, Timestamp Manipulation, Proxying	Deleted logs, manipulated file timestamps, and routed traffic through U.S.-based university

				systems to obscure origins.
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2.4 Impact caused

The main impacts and effect of this breach are as followed: -

- a. Strategic Effect: USA'S National defence secrets were compromised.
- b. Economic Effect: Millions in R&D value lost; increased cybersecurity costs across the defence industry.
- c. Allied Risk: Subcontractors and foreign buyers of Lockheed products were put at risk due to potential compromise of tech specs and vulnerabilities.
- d. Rapid Chinese advancements in stealth aircraft designs, including similarities between the F-35 and China's J-31 fighter jet. (Mandient, 2013)

3. Section 2

3.1 Governing Bodies investigating APTs and Personal Data Loss

When a cyberattack leads to personal data loss, both national and international authorities step in to investigate and ensure that affected

organizations comply with data protection and cybersecurity regulations. These bodies are responsible for enforcing laws, conducting investigations, penalizing non-compliance, and guiding best practices.

3.1.1 National Governing Bodies

- United States:
 1. The Federal Bureau of Investigations (FBI)—They have national security concerns focusing on serious cyber-related crimes.
 2. Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA)—They help with response actions from substantive breaches within specific critical infrastructure sectors.
- United Kingdom:
 1. Information Commissioner's Office (ICO) – Implements laws governing data protection.
- European Union:
 1. European Data Protection Board (EDPB), National Data Protection Authorities.

3.2 Companies Responsibilities After a Cyberattack

Upon learning it has been a victim of a cyberattack, a company must:

Notify Authorities:

- In the U.S., companies must notify the FTC and affected individuals, often within 30-60 days (ftc.gov, 2021).

- Under GDPR (Europe), companies must report breaches to a Data Protection Authority within 72 hours (gdpr, 2016).

Inform Affected Individuals:

- Organizations must promptly inform affected users about what personal data was compromised and provide guidance on protective actions.

Conduct a Full Investigation:

- Companies must determine the breach's scope, identify vulnerabilities exploited, and document all steps taken post-incident.

Mitigate Further Risk:

- Immediate actions include patching vulnerabilities, resetting compromised credentials, and deploying intrusion prevention systems. Lockheed Martin would have updated software (e.g., Java, Adobe) exploited by APT1 and enhanced network monitoring to detect residual threats.
- Long-term measures involve adopting frameworks like NIST 800-171 for defence contractors, which mandates robust access controls and encryption.

Maintain Documentation:

- Companies must keep detailed records of the breach, investigation, notifications, and remediation steps for regulatory audits. GDPR requires documentation for at least three years, while U.S. regulations like DFARS mandate ongoing compliance reporting. Lockheed Martin's documentation would have included Mandiant's forensic report and DoD correspondence (GDPR, 2025).

3.3 Consequences Imposed by Governing Bodies

If companies fail to comply with regulations or demonstrate negligence, governing bodies can impose:

Fines:

- GDPR fines up to €20 million or 4% of global turnover; ICO fines in the UK; FTC civil penalties.

Regulatory Sanctions

- Mandated audits and third-party risk assessments.
- Imposed improvements to cybersecurity programs.
- Possible suspension of operations handling sensitive data until compliance is achieved.

Criminal Investigations

- Severe negligence, such as failing to report a breach or ignoring known vulnerabilities, may trigger criminal probes. In the U.S., the FBI could investigate if Lockheed Martin's breach endangered national security. In the EU, DPAs can refer cases to law enforcement for will full misconduct.

Civil Litigation

- Affected individuals or partners may file class-action lawsuits for damages. For example, Equifax faced over \$1 billion in claims from consumers post-2017 breach. Lockheed Martin's subcontractors, if impacted, could have pursued legal action for losses tied to compromised data.

Reputational Damage

- Beyond formal penalties, breaches erode customer and partner trust. Lockheed Martin's reputation as a secure defence contractor was likely scrutinized by the DoD and allies, potentially affecting future contracts.

4. Section 3

4.1 Impact Assessment of the APT 1 Attack

The APT1 attack on Lockheed Martin had far-reaching consequences, affecting national security, economic stability, operational efficiency, corporate reputation, and international relations. This section provides a detailed assessment of these impacts, incorporating additional context, data, and examples to highlight the breach's severity and long-term implications.

4.1.1 Financial consequences

The financial fallout from APT1's attack on Lockheed Martin extended beyond immediate incident response costs. The theft of classified design documents and proprietary technologies meant that billions of dollars invested in research and development (R&D) were effectively compromised. According to RAND Corporation's studies on cybersecurity breaches (MARTIN C. LIBICKI, 2015), intellectual property theft can erode competitive advantage and reduce future revenue streams.

Costs included:

- Comprehensive forensic investigations.
- Immediate and long-term cybersecurity infrastructure upgrades.
- Legal fees related to breach disclosure and compliance.
- Increased insurance premiums for cyber risk coverage.

Overall, the economic loss associated with espionage in the defence sector is estimated to be in the billions annually (The U.S.-China Economic and Security Review Commission, 2013).

4.1.2 Operational Disruptions

The APT1 attack disrupted Lockheed Martin's operations, diverting resources from core activities and affecting its supply chain and program timelines.

- **Resource Diversion:** Engineering and development teams were sidelined to support incident response, delaying critical projects like the F-35. Forensic teams, IT staff, and executives focused on containment and recovery, reducing productivity (Mandiant, 2013). Per Pokémon Institute's 2023 data, breaches cause an average of 21% productivity loss in affected organizations.
- **Supply Chain Impact:** APT1 likely targeted subcontractors, as defence programs involve extensive partner networks. Compromised subcontractors required security audits and system upgrades, disrupting supply chain workflows (Mandiant, 2013). For

example, a 2011 RSA breach (another APT) affected Lockheed Martin's supply chain, highlighting vulnerabilities in third-party systems.

- **Program Delays:** The F-35 program, already complex, may have faced delays as Lockheed Martin reassessed the security of its engineering servers and source code repositories. Such delays increase costs and strain relationships with the DoD and international buyers (e.g., NATOintrexate.com estimates that disruptions from major breaches can delay projects by 3–6 months, costing millions (MITRE, 2017).

4.1.3 Reputational Damage

When it comes to defence contractors operating with national governments, reputation is crucial for business. Customers like the U.S. Department of defence and allied countries put greater focus on Lockheed Martin. Everything the business does tends to oscillate between capitalism and socialism – Lockheed Martin stating “no classified information was compromised” is a perfect example for this. The company suffered an image setback as a reliable and secure defence supplier due to the perception that they fell victim to a sophisticated cyber-attack. Trust is vital in any business and its absence can impact future contracts and partnerships (Mandient, 2013).

4.1.4 Geopolitical Consequences

The attack impacted international relations on a wider scale. While China accelerated the Chengdu J-20 fifth-generation fighter development, APT1's espionage activities were contemporaneous to China's progress. The unapproved leakage of American military technology not only advanced their hostile capabilities, but also transformed the strategic dominance of military forces across the Asia-Pacific region (The U.S.-China Economic and Security Review Commission, 2013).

4.2 Mitigation Strategies

Stopping APTs requires a mix of technology, training, and strategy. This section outlines practical steps companies can take before, during, and after an attack, drawing lessons from APT 1.

4.2.1 Pre-Attack Strategies (Proactive Defence)

a. Employee Training and Phishing Awareness:

- Regular and updated cybersecurity training designed to recognise the different types of phishing attacks could have mitigated lots of initial access vectors.
- Simulated phishing attack would have helped employees identify the potential phishing email.

b. Up to date Software:

- Implementing auto updates on different software like Microsoft Office, Java, and Adobe software would reduce the risk by a lot.

c. Zero Trust Architecture:

- Implementing a "never trust, always verify" model could restrict lateral movement even if initial compromise occurs.

4.2.2 During-Attack Strategies (Active Defence)

Real-Time Threat Detection:

- Deployment of Endpoint Detection and Response (EDR) tools capable of traffic packet analysis.

Example: Crowd strike's Falcon platform flags RATs in real time.

Network Segmentation:

- Restricting access to sensitive systems would limit an attacker's ability to traverse the network freely.

Incident Response Playbooks:

- Predefined containment strategies, such as isolating infected endpoints, could have limited the attack's scope.

4.2.3 Post-Attack Strategies (Recovery and Improvement)

Forensic Analysis:

- Comprehensive forensic audits post-breach can identify how attackers gained and maintained access, guiding improvements.

Public Communication Strategy:

- Transparent communication with stakeholders and government rebuilds trust and shows the will to redeem themselves.

Strengthened Supplier Requirements:

- Imposing cybersecurity standards on subcontractors and vendors.

4.3 Lessons Learned and Reflection

4.3.1 Importance of Early Detection and Response

One of the primary lessons from the APT1 attack is the need for swift detection. APTs operate over long periods precisely because traditional defences are often reactive rather than proactive. Investing in threat hunting teams and continuous monitoring drastically reduces "dwell time," the duration attackers remain undetected (Mandiant, 2013).

4.3.2 Supply Chain Security

The Lockheed Martin incident highlighted that a company's security is only as strong as its weakest link. Subcontractors with less stringent security protocols are attractive targets for adversaries seeking indirect access. Comprehensive vetting and auditing of supply chain cybersecurity practices have since become industry best practices.

4.3.3 Investment in Threat Intelligence and Collaboration

Collaboration research between private companies and government cybersecurity agencies, such as the Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA), can provide actionable intelligence that pre-empts attacks. Information sharing mechanisms reduce the isolation that APTs exploit.

4.3.4 The Shift Toward Zero Trust Architecture

The principle of Zero Trust, which assumes breach and verifies every user and device at each step, has gained momentum. Applying micro-

segmentation, strong identity management, and continuous authentication would significantly hinder APT movement within networks.

4.3.5 Importance of Incident Preparedness

Finally, preparedness and simulation exercises help organizations test their defences under realistic conditions. Table top exercises involving executives, IT, and legal teams ensure that when an attack happens, responses are coordinated and efficient.

4.4 Conclusion

The APT 1 attack on Lockheed Martin was a massive wake-up call, exposing just how brutal cyber espionage can hit. It wasn't just a financial gut-punch—costing billions in stolen F-35 research, forensic investigations, and beefed-up cybersecurity—it rocked U.S. national security to its core. By swiping cutting-edge jet designs, China fast-tracked its own stealth fighters like the J-31, shifting the military balance in the Asia-Pacific and stirring up global tensions. Lockheed Martin's operations took a hit too, with engineers and IT teams side lined to clean up the mess, delaying the F-35 program and disrupting its supply chain. Subcontractors, often the weakest link, needed costly security overhauls, proving no one's safe, no matter how big they are. The reputational damage was rough—Lockheed Martin's claim that “no classified data was lost” didn't fully calm the nerves of the DoD or allies, risking future contracts.

But there's light at the end of this tunnel. Learning from this chaos means getting proactive. Regular employee training to spot sneaky phishing emails, auto-updating software like Java and Adobe, and adopting a Zero Trust mindset—where you trust no one until verified—can stop attacks before they dig in. During a breach, tools like CrowdStrike's Falcon platform, which catches malware in real time, and network segmentation to lock down

sensitive systems, can keep the damage low. Post-attack, forensic audits uncover how hackers got in, while honest communication with stakeholders rebuilds trust. Lockheed Martin's transparency with the DoD was a step in the right direction here.

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